On 16 July, only forty-eight hours after his first meeting with Macnaghten, Shuja signed what later became known as the Tripartite Alliance.

The Simla season, thought Emily Eden, had got off to a most satisfactory start. ‘We give sundry dinners and occasional balls,’ she wrote happily to her sister in England, ‘and have hit on one popular device. Our band plays once a week on one of the hills here, and we send ices and refreshments to the listeners, and it makes a nice little reunion with very little trouble.’[125] Her only complaint was that the steamer *Semiramis* which was meant to take her letters to London had sailed off to deliver the naval squadron to Kharg in the Gulf, and her post was still stuck in Bombay: ‘We try all sorts of plans; but, first, the monsoon cripples one steamer, and the next comes back with all the letters still on board that we fondly thought were in England. Then we try an Arab sailing vessel; but I always feel convinced that an Arab ship sails wildly about drinking coffee and robbing other ships . . .’[126]

Meanwhile, high on his Himalayan ledge, her brother was finalising his plans for a full-scale British invasion of Afghanistan. He was still, however, racked with indecision and rattled by the critical letters he began to receive from old India hands. Charles Metcalfe, who had been acting Governor General in the period up to Auckland’s arrival, and who many believed should have had the job in preference to him, had expressed his deep forebodings about Auckland’s Afghan policies. ‘We have needlessly and heedlessly plunged into difficulties and embarrassments,’ he wrote, ‘from which we can never extricate ourselves without a disgraceful retreat. Our sole course is to resist the influence of Russia, yet our measures are almost sure to establish it . . . The only certain results, even in the event of brilliant success in the first instance, are permanent embarrassments and difficulties, political and financial . . .’

Britain’s foremost Afghan expert, Mountstuart Elphinstone, was equally sceptical. ‘If you send 27,000 men up the Bolan Pass to Candahar (as we hear is intended) and can feed them, I have no doubt you will take Candahar and Cabul and set up Shuja,’ he observed. ‘But for maintaining him in a poor, cold, strong and remote country, among a turbulent people like the Afghans, I own it seems to me hopeless. If you succeed I fear you will